CLIMATE & ENVIRONMENT

The Climate Fight: What Is the Hard Part?

Global · November 8, 2026



Wind turbines above green fields beneath a clouded sky. · AI-generated image

There may be more than one road to the same goal, but the road taken must be neither so strict that states give up nor so loose that insufficient effort goes unpunished. The Kyoto Protocol and the Paris Agreement were both ratified by many states to slow the warming of the planet by cutting greenhouse gas emissions. The Kyoto Protocol sought to back its targets with sanctions; the states that ratified the Paris Agreement set their targets freely, without fear of sanctions.

Under Kyoto, only developed countries had committed to reducing greenhouse gas emissions. The United States, one of the biggest emitters, did not ratify the protocol, while countries classed as developing, such as China and India, were exempt from binding reduction targets. Canada, which had ratified it, became the first state to withdraw. Because it left before the end of the first period over which emissions were to be measured, it faced no sanctions.

All the other states with targets met them on paper, but some got there by buying carbon credits. And because some major emitters, as developing countries, were under no obligation to set targets, the rise in emissions could not be slowed as much as intended. Under this protocol, the uneven sharing of the reduction burden and its high cost, together with the prospect of sanctions, daunted states. A state that could not meet its target on its own would either have to buy carbon credits or be held to a higher reduction target for the next period: punished, in other words, with more of the very thing it had already failed to do.

The Paris Agreement, by contrast, set out from the start to encourage rather than punish: that was the price of keeping every party in the game. So, with no threat of sanctions, what would move states to act? One might expect a state's effort in this fight to grow in proportion to the cost of the disasters that climate change is likely to bring its way. Yet the overall trend can only be judged fairly if we bear in mind that not every country fighting emissions is a developed one, and that states struggling with more urgent needs are part of this effort too. Indeed, the Paris Agreement recognized from the outset that it would take longer for emissions in developing countries to stop rising and begin to fall.

In fact, whichever road is taken, states will pose distinct challenges because of their differing characteristics. The largest sources of the greenhouse gas emissions that have been climbing since the Industrial Revolution lie in humanity's basic needs, such as energy production, industry, transportation, buildings, agriculture and land use. Knowing the sources also reveals the main routes to cutting emissions. But it does not guarantee that every step along the way will be equally easy.

The more widely an emission source is used, the harder it is to fight. The United Kingdom, for example, came through its tough test with coal by closing its last coal-fired power plant. Yet even though coal plants were far fewer than the vehicles in domestic transportation and the buildings that need heating, this test took decades. With the fight now set to concentrate on transportation and heating, the test of cutting emissions has become several notches harder at once.

The difficulty may also lie in the size of the targets themselves. Australia, one of the countries that set an ambitious reduction target, has made progress with renewables in its electricity supply; still, it needs wide-ranging policies and plans to match the scale of its goals. But to take effect in time, such plans and policies need both swift procedures and public support for the changes they bring.

Being exposed to the dangers of a climate crisis driven by greenhouse gases will not, by itself, bring the money and capacity the fight requires. The climate crisis, however, needs no visa to cross borders, and the crises that erupt in individual countries end up having global effects. Chile is one of the countries caught right in the middle of this predicament. Add the flood risk forecast along its central coast to the danger of high temperatures in its northern regions, and a bigger fight becomes unavoidable; Chile does have plans and legislation for this. But the fight against the climate crisis is also a fight against its allies, such as a lack of capacity and funding. Even strong economies, to say nothing of developing countries, find each financial step more exhausting than the last as they change their habits.

On the other hand, not every drop in the statistics is necessarily a sign of success in the fight. Some statistics mask carbon leakage or similar effects. Japan, for instance, named the decarbonization of power generation and falling domestic output in manufacturing as the main reasons its emissions declined. But a decline in domestic manufacturing does not show that consumption of goods whose production generates emissions has fallen too. In cases like these, then, the emissions do not disappear; they merely move elsewhere and live on as a global burden.

Like individuals, states sometimes seem willing and then back down along the way. If commitments are backed by sanctions, the loopholes in agreements must be closed so that no party can walk away without paying a price, as was possible under Kyoto. If they are not, it is probably wiser to build the main plan around how states have behaved in the past. Indeed, Canada, the first country to abandon the Kyoto Protocol, makes the point clearer: through regulations that halted the fuel charge, it has done away with mandatory carbon pricing for consumers.

Clearly, the fight against emissions and the climate crisis is costly for states. Still, they may seem to have stayed in the game. So, as governments change and economic conditions bear down on them, will a sanction-free way of setting targets turn this whole effort into group therapy? We do not know the answer yet, but unless carbon emissions are cut on a large scale, the world will keep warming. As storms grow fiercer, we may see a considerable rise in floods and in the number of species that disappear. Perhaps, a few decades from now, when scientists look back at the genetic maps of natural disasters, they will realize that the disasters yet to come because of the global climate crisis descend from the same lineage as the ones we have been living through for some time.

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